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Flood may keep mine closed indefinite period

Canadian Press

JORDAN RIVER — Heavy rains swelling the Jordan River have threatened indefinite extension of Friday's closure of the Cowichan Copper Co. mine near here.

The mine was closed after the river broke into the mine's main tunnel, flooding mine workings and an underground processing plant. The firm's 125 workers were laid off.

Mine manager J. R. Billingsley said a crew is going through the mine to estimate damage. But he "couldn't begin to guess" when operations might resume.

He said tentative plans are for an eight-man repair crew to start work about the middle of this week.

"We are anxious to get as many men back to work as possible," he said.

The river's full force is flowing through the mine, leaving it through the portal a full mile from where a hole in the riverbed was produced by a stope cave-in.

Mine officials said they knew the spot, 60 feet from the river's edge, was weak. They had posted a lookout in the mined-out stope to warn of any leakages.

Reinforcing of the stope with steel and concrete buttressing was completed in mid-September.

Billingsley said a deposit of gravel about 1,000 yards upstream from the cave-in will be pumped into the hole to plug the stope, and a concrete cap will seal it off.

He said no attempt will be made to divert the river. Instead, the flow of water will be used to carry the gravel into place. More than 1,000 cubic yards of fill will be needed.

The mine manager said that as far as he knows no damage has been done to mine equipment. Almost all the mine's equipment is underground but most of it is high in the tunnel, probably clear of the water.

Main fear is that the water and silt might have damaged electrical equipment in the crushing mill, which is under three feet of water.

Jordan River is 40 miles from Victoria on the west coast of Vancouver Island.

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